

## The Rubber Stamp

**N**arinder Nath Vohra, a former home secretary and ironically, a former interlocutor for Kashmir in 2003, took over as Governor of Jammu and Kashmir right in the midst of the Amarnath land row. Instead of mitigating the situation, his first action as governor was to further intensify the crisis. Four days after he moved into the Raj Bhavan, he wrote a letter to the then chief minister indicating that on second thoughts, the Shri Amarnath Shrine Board (of which the governor is the chairman) did not actually need the land. Instead the government could look after the facilities for the pilgrims. This, in effect, nullified the May 26 order of the Ghulam Nabi Azad government.

Vohra clearly thought that he had solved the crisis. His action aggravated the crisis, sparking protests from the Amarnath Sangharsh Samiti which began its now nearly two-month-long agitation, demanding that the land be "returned" to the shrine board. With one stroke of his pen, Vohra single-handedly sparked off phase two of the current crisis. He failed to calm the agitators

and convey to the public the true spirit of the order. Vohra came with an advantage. Due to his earlier stint as interlocutor, he already had a channel of communication with the separatists. By sending him to the troubled state, the Centre was hoping he could turn the crisis around. But he was unable to convince the Hurriyat that contrary to the propaganda set off by his predecessor Lt-General (retd) S.K. Sinha's office, the land had not been permanently bequeathed to the board.

To be sure, as governor, Vohra got his orders from the Centre. And he was being guided by the PMO that was on the verge of a crucial trust vote and needed to appease both the PDP's one vote and NC's two votes to save the Government. But now let alone the BJP, even state Congressmen are asking for his ouster. This trust deficit is not a very reassuring position for a state that is currently under governor's rule. *by Priya Sahgal*

"IN JAMMU, THEY ASK ME ARE YOU NOT A HINDU? YOU TOOK AWAY THE LAND FROM THE SHRINE."

N.N. Vohra, Governor



SIPRA DAS